ribbon and pinned it on Manekshaw, saying, “A dead person cannot be awarded a Military Cross.”

RAMESHWAR NATH KAO

1918–2002



“KNOWLEDGE IS POWER AND THE PROVERB HOLDS TRUE FOR INTELLIGENCE AGENCIES MORE THAN ANY OTHER ENTITY.”

RN Kao was the founding director of the R&AW or RAW. He began his career in the police before moving to the Intelligence Bureau (IB), India’s only intelligence agency at the time. In 1968, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi asked Kao to set up a new agency to gather information on external threats. As R&AW’s first head, Kao had to set up the agency’s capacities, create infrastructure and systems, and deploy covert agents—spies—in key locations across the world. Of special interest were India’s neighbours, Pakistan and China. Information gathered by R&AW helped India to victory in 1971.